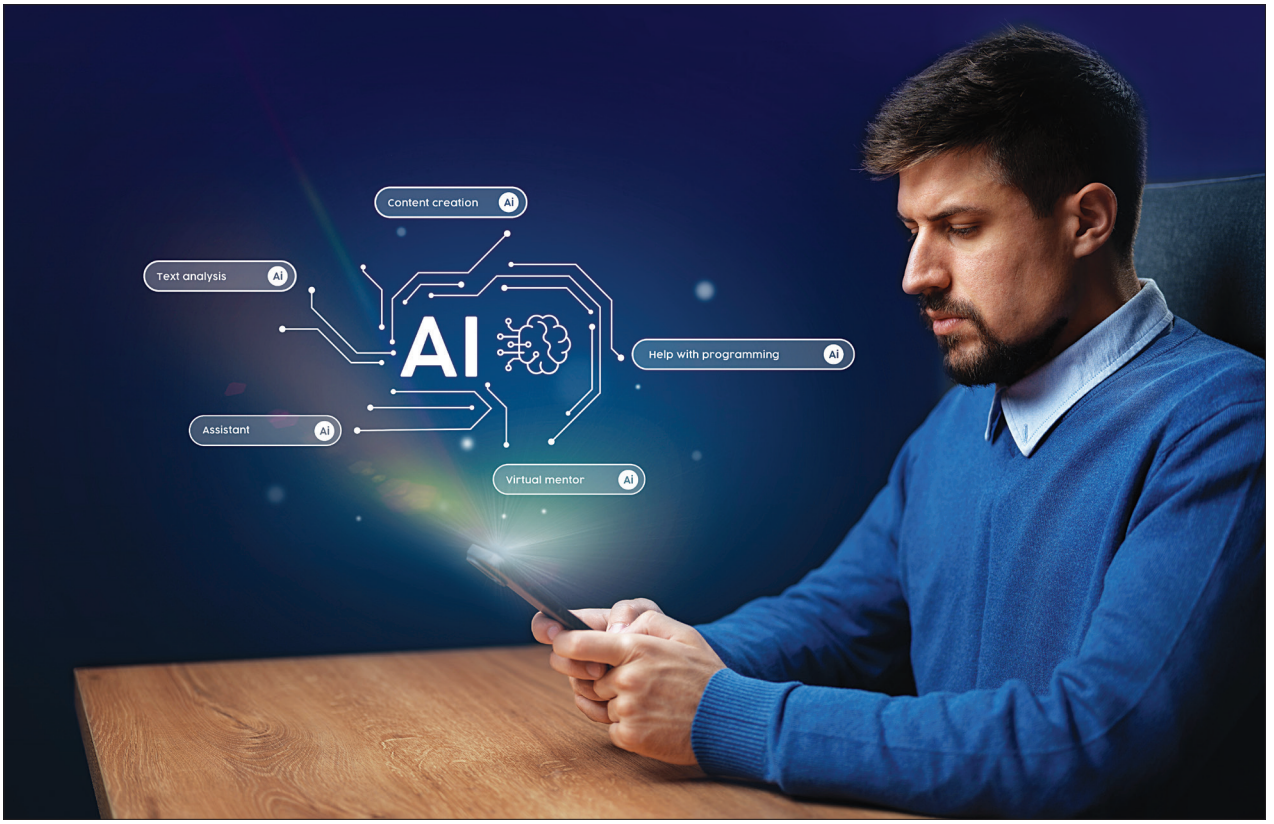


From Model to AI System

Turn a working model into a complete AI system

Getting a model to answer a prompt on your own machine feels like a finish line. In reality, it is closer to switching on an engine sitting on a workshop floor. The engine may be powerful and entirely under your control, but it is not yet a car. It has no steering, navigation or brakes, and no idea where you want to go.

The same applies to a locally running large language model. By itself, the model accepts tokens and predicts what tokens should come next. The useful system around it decides what instructions it receives, which documents it can consult, what information it remembers, which tools it is allowed to use, how its output is checked and what the user finally sees.

That is our starting point. Part 1 of this series was about choosing and running the engine. From here onward, we build the vehicle around it.

A model isn't an AI application

Suppose you have an instruction-tuned open model running through your preferred local runtime. Ask it to draft an email and it probably can. Ask it to summarise text pasted into the prompt